



Siddha at Glance

The word Siddha has its origin in the Tamil word *Siddhi* which means "an object to be attained" or "perfection" or "heavenly bliss". India being the birth place of many traditional philosophies also gave birth to Siddha.

The system of medicine is believed to be preached by Lord Shiva to His consort Parvati, then by Her to Nandidevar who passed on the knowledge of Siddha to Siddhars for the benefit of humanity. Siddhars are people who have attained *Siddhi*, i.e., heavenly bliss. They developed and practised the eight levels to attain eternal bliss, viz., *Astanga Yogam*.

These eight levels are:

Eyamam	Good thoughts
Niyamam	Good deeds
Asanam	Posture of the body
Pranayamam	Control of breath
Prathiyakaram	Restraint of senses from their objects of enjoyment
Tharanai	Focusing of mind
Dyanam	De-concentration
Samaadhi	Super consciousness

They were also said to possess eight supernatural powers called *Ashtamasiddhigal* which are *Anima, Mahima, Lahima, Karima, Praapti, Prahamiyam, Vasithuvam and Esathuvam*. Many Siddhars are considered to have contributed to the Siddha system of medicine and among them Agathiyar is considered to be the foremost Siddhar. Their contributions were mainly classified into the following four categories:

i.Gnanam Spiritual knowledge

ii.Yogam Yogic Principles, meditation techniques

iii.Vaatham Alchemy and the like practices

iv.Vaidhyam Medical practices

Each of these practices is aimed towards maintenance of a healthy body and healthy mind which forms the basis to attain eternal bliss. The Siddha system in its unique approach stresses upon several routine and seasonal regimen as preventive measures against illness of body and mind. This system lays significant emphasis on diet as it plays a very important role in the maintenance of a healthy body - the ground which nurtures a healthy mind. The basis of this system is the physiological doctrine of three humors viz., *Vaatham, Pitham and Kabham* collectively known as *Uyir Thathukkal*. Accordingly, each individual is considered to have a unique body composition and this system of medicine has an individualistic approach in preservation of health.

Siddha traditional medicine formulations till date included in the Traditional Knowledge Digital Library are 23,016.





Siddha-Basic Concepts and Principles

Introduction

The Siddha system of medicine mainly practised in the Southern part of India is one of the earliest traditional medicine systems in the world and deals with physical, psychological, social and spiritual well being of an individual. The roots of this system are intertwined with the culture of ancient Tamil civilization.

Basic Concept

In the Siddha system of medicine, man is viewed as a microcosm and the universe as a macrocosm. In other words, man is a miniature universe in himself. The whole universe in turn is believed to be constituted of five primordial elements or *Panchabhootham* viz. Earth, Water, Fire, Air and Space and so is man. The *Pancheekaranam* theory (Five Fold Combination) of Siddha science explains the origin and formation of these basic elements as well as the role of these five elements in the formation of every substance both in the universe and in humans.

According to *Pancheekaranam* theory, each of these five elements is said to possess two properties viz. subtle and gross. These elements always act in mutual co-ordination and can never act independently. The various proportions in which they combine gives rise to different substances. Thus, this theory proposes that 96 basic factors exist, which is the basic concept underlying this holistic medical science.

The human body formed by these 96 basic factors is conditioned mainly by:

1) *Uyir Thathukkal* (also called *Trithodam* or *Mukkutram*) are the three humours, viz. *vaatham, pitham and kabham*.

2) *Udal Thathukkal* are the physical constituents, or the seven tissues viz. *Saaram, Senneer, Oon, Konzhuppu, Enbu, Moolai* and *Sukkilam*.

The 96 factors include physical, physiological, psychological, intellectual aspects of every human. The five primordial elements manifest themselves as a human through these 96 basic factors.

Panchabootham	Five elements	5
Pori	Sense organs	5
Pulan	Five senses	5
Kanmenthiriyam	Motor organs	5
Gnanendiriyam	Functions of motor organs	5
Karanam	Intellect	4
Arivu	Self realization	1
Naadi	Channels of life force	10
Vaayu	Vital nerve force	10
Aasayam	Metabolic sheaths	5
Kosam	Five sheaths	5
Aathaaram	Nerve plexus	5
Mandalam	Sheaths of humours	6
Malam	Impurities related to soul	3
Thodam	Humours	3
Edanai	Attachments, desires related to the soul	3
Gunam	Qualities of mind	3
Vinai	Physical and mental acts	2
Raagam	Emotional status of mind	8
Avasthai	Status of consciousness	5

TOTAL BASIC FACTORS		96

Relationship between the basic elements (*Panchabhootam*), five sense organs (*Pori*) and functions of these sense organs (*Pulan*) can be understood from the tabulation below:

Panchabhootam	Sense organs	Functions of sense organs
Earth (*Nilam*)	Nose	Smell
Water (*Neer*)	Mouth	Taste
Fire (*Thee*)	Eyes	Vision
Air (*Kaatru*)	Skin	Touch
Space (*Aagayam*)	Ears	Hearing

It can be deduced from the above table that the sense of smell perceived by the sense organ nose, is due to the action and properties of the element, 'earth'. Similarly, the other senses can be linked to corresponding elements.

***Uyir Thathukkal* (Three Humours)**

Uyir thathukkal literally means 'life force'. In Siddha, *Vaatham, Pitham* and *Kabham* which are the three humours, are responsible for the creation, preservation and destruction of human body and health. When they are in the state of equilibrium (4:2:1-the ratio in which they exist) our body remains in a healthy state while any disturbance in this ratio leads to diseased state or death.

Vaatham

Vaatham represents the elements 'air' and 'space'. It is responsible for all movements of mind and body. Motor, sensory activities are governed by *vaatham*. Although *vaatham* is present all over the body, it predominates in the region below navel and based on its function it is classified into the following ten types:

S.No	**Type of *Vaatham***	**Function**
1	*Piranan*	Controls respiration and circulation
2	*Abanan*	Controls excretory acts
3	*Viyanan*	Spread all over the body and controls body movements
4	*Samanan*	Controls digestion, absorption and assimilation
5	*Udhanan*	Controls speech

6	*Naagan*	Responsible for knowledge and skills
7	*Koorman*	Provides strength, vision
8	*Kirugaran*	Responsible for taste, appetite, reflexes
9	*Devathathan*	Responsible for emotions like anger
10	*Thananjeyan*	Gets expelled out from the body on 3rd day after death

Roughness, dryness, lightness and mobility are certain attributes of *Vaatham*.It also strengthens the five sensory organs, and regulates respiration, the functions of physical constituents (*Udal thathukkal*) and physiological reflexes (also called *Vegangal*).

Pitham

Pitham represents the element-'fire' (*thee*)in our body and is responsible for the preservation of health. It maintains the body heat for normal physiology and dominates the chest and abdominal area. It exhibits itself in five forms within our body. They are:

S.No	**Type of *Pitham***	**Function**
1	*Anala Pitham*	Involved in digestion
2	*Ranjaga Pitham*	Involved in blood cells production
3	*Saathaga Pitham*	Involved in intellectual acts
4	*Aalosaga Pitham*	Gives colour and shine to skin
5	*Pirasaga Pitham*	Involved in visualizing and analyzing process

Kabham

Kabham is formed by the elements 'earth and water'. It is responsible for strength, joint movements, body built and endurance. It dominates the head and neck region. There are five forms of *Kabham* as follows

S.No	**Type of Kabham**	**Function**
1	*Avalambagam*	Located in the lungs and co-ordinates the other forms of kabham
2	*Kilaetham*	Aids digestion
3	*Pothagam*	Helps in perception of taste
4	*Tharpagam*	Cools the eyes

5	*Santhigam*	Responsible for movements of joints

***Udal Thathukkal* (Physical constituents)**

The human body is constituted of seven tissues as its physical constituents, which are known as the *Udal Thathukkal*.

Physical constituents (Udal Thathukkal)	**Related Body Constituents**	**Basic Elements**
Saaram	Plasma	Water
Senneer	Blood	Fire + Water
Oon	Muscle	Earth + Water
Kozhuppu	Adipose tissue	Water + Earth
Enbu	Bone	Earth + Air
Moolai	Marrow	Water + Air
Sukkilam/Suronitham	Male or Female Hormones, Reproductive tissue.	Fire + Air

Each of the above physical constituent is responsible for certain functions:

Physical constituents (*Udal Thathukkal*)	**Functions**
Saaram	Growth and development, nourishment
Senneer	Nourishes the muscle, imparts colour and improve intellect
Ooun	Responsible for shape of the body
Kozhuppu	Lubricates joints, maintains balance
Enbu	Supports body structure and responsible for posture and movement
Moolai	Imparts strength, endurance and shine
Sukkilam/Suronitham	Responsible for reproduction

The food we intake nourishes each of the physical constituent in a sequence beginning from *Saaram* and provides total nourishment to the body on eighth day, after nourishing each constituent.





Principles of Siddha

Siddhars have recommended certain basic guidelines to be followed for healthy living which includes observation of certain regimen as mentioned in *"Pini anugaa vidhi"* literally meaning rules that help prevent disease. Their concept of *"Kaayakarpam"* for prevention of diseases is highly admirable as it makes one's body resistant to infections. Their concepts pertaining to Habitat, Seasons, Diet *(Thinai/Nilam, Naal ozhukkam, Kaala ozhukkam, Unavu)* are preventive as well as adaptive.

1. *Pini Anugaa Vidhi* (Prevention of diseases)

"Thinna mirandulae sikka adakkaamar..." -- Therayar

" Paal unbhom; ennai perin veneerir kulippom..." -- Therayar

The above verses illustrate the do's and don'ts in all our activities. These preventive measures against illness are summarized below:

i. Drink boiled water

ii. Take meals twice a day

iii.Take diluted buttermilk and melted ghee

iv. Take sufficient quantity of milk and milk products

v. Never eat root tubers except yam

vi. Never consume food that was prepared the previous day

vii. Always have food after feeling hungery

viii. Always consume sour curd

ix. Practice walking after a good diet

x. Drink water at the end of meals

xi. Use hot water while taking oil bath.

xii. Never suppress any natural urge

xiii. Never sleep during daytime

xiv. Always indulge in healthy sexual acts

xv. Take emetic medication once in six months

xvi. Take purgative medication every four months in a year

xvii. Take snuff medications eight times in a year

xviii. Shave hairs weekly

xix. Take oil bath once in every four days

xx. Apply eye medications once in three days

xxi. Never smell fragrance during midnight

xxii. Never reside close to dust and articles related to dust

xxiii. Never sleep under a tree shade or near a burning lamp

These rules when followed strictly, keep away death. These simple preventive principles have an in depth scientific value though they were designed much before the advent of modern science. These rules have been followed as routine custom through several generations.

2. *Kaaya Karpam* (Gerontology)

"Udambar azhiyil uyirar azhivar..."-- Thirumandiram by Thirumoolar

The above quote states that maintaining a healthy body is essential as it holds a healthy mind which is required to attain salvation. Adoption of preventive techniques to maintain one's body health helps to retain youthfulness and attain spiritual perfection.*"Kaaya Karpam"* (rejuvenation and longevity) was practiced as a preventive measure against illness. Practicing Kaaya Karpam also provides acquired immunity *(seyarkai vanmai)* to our body. *Kaaya Karpam* acts in 2 ways i.e., prevention against disease and restoration of health during illness. Thus, it is preventive as well as constructive. *Kaaya Karpam* is studied under three categories viz.

i. Mooligai Karpam

ii. Thathu and Seeva Karpam

iii. Yoga Karpam

i) *Mooligai Karpam*

This deals with drugs used in Siddha for *Kaaya Karpam* (rejuvenation and longevity) which have plant origin

Ex: - Fruits of *Phyllanthus emblica* (Amla)

ii) *Thathu and Seeva Karpam*

This deals with minerals and animal products used as *Kaaya Karpam* preparations. This also includes *"Muppu"* (A combination of three salts) - a very unique preparation in Siddha.

iii) *Yoga Karpam* (Yogic Practices)

Yogasanam, Pranayamam, Iyamam, and *Niyamam* fall under this category.

Siddhars have described several yogic postures which are aimed at developing and maintaining the wellness of the body and soul. Saint Thirumoolar has detailed several yogasanas (yogic postures) in his valuable work titled *'Thirumandiram'*.

3. Concepts regarding habitat and season

Siddha science which visualizes man as a microcosm, believes that planetary changes and natural rhythms that result in six seasons/year *(perum pozhuthu)* and six periods/day *(siru pozhuthu)* also result in corresponding physiological changes in other creatures living in macrocosm, viz., the Universe.

"Andathil ullathae Pindam,

Pindathil ullathae Andam ..."

-- Satta Muni Gnanam

This verse means that the environment is same within and outside our body which indicates that the body physiology must be tuned according to the habitat and the prevailing season as an adaptive and preventive measure for one's health.

Accordingly, Siddhars designed basic regimen in harmony with the habitat *(Nilam)* and seasons *(Pozhuthu)*.

Habitat *(Nilam)*

Habitat or nilam indicates the place where one lives. On the basis of certain characteristic features like geographical (landscape) conditions, climatic conditions, flora, fauna, etc., habitat is categorized as follows:

i. Hilly tract *(Kurinji)*

ii. Sylvan tract *(Mullai)*

iii. Agricultural tract *(Marutham)*

iv. Coastal tract *(Neithal)* and

v. Arid tract *(Paalai)*

Each habitat is said to harbour a particular humour (Uyir Thathu). The influence of habitat on the incidence of the diseases was predicted as follows.

This can be interpreted from the following table

Habitat (Nilam)	**Geographical description**	**Prevalent disease**
Hilly tract	Mountains and its surroundings	*Kabham* related disease and liver disease
Sylvan tract	Forest and its surroundings	*Pitham, vaatham* related diseases and liver disease
Agricultural tract	Fields and its surroundings	Ideal place for healthy living
Coastal Tract	Ocean, sea and its surroundings	*Vaatham* related disease and liver disease
Arid Tract	Desert and its surroundings	*Vaatham, pitham, kabham* related diseases

The following table depicts the state of predominant humour (Uyir thathu) in each type of habitat.

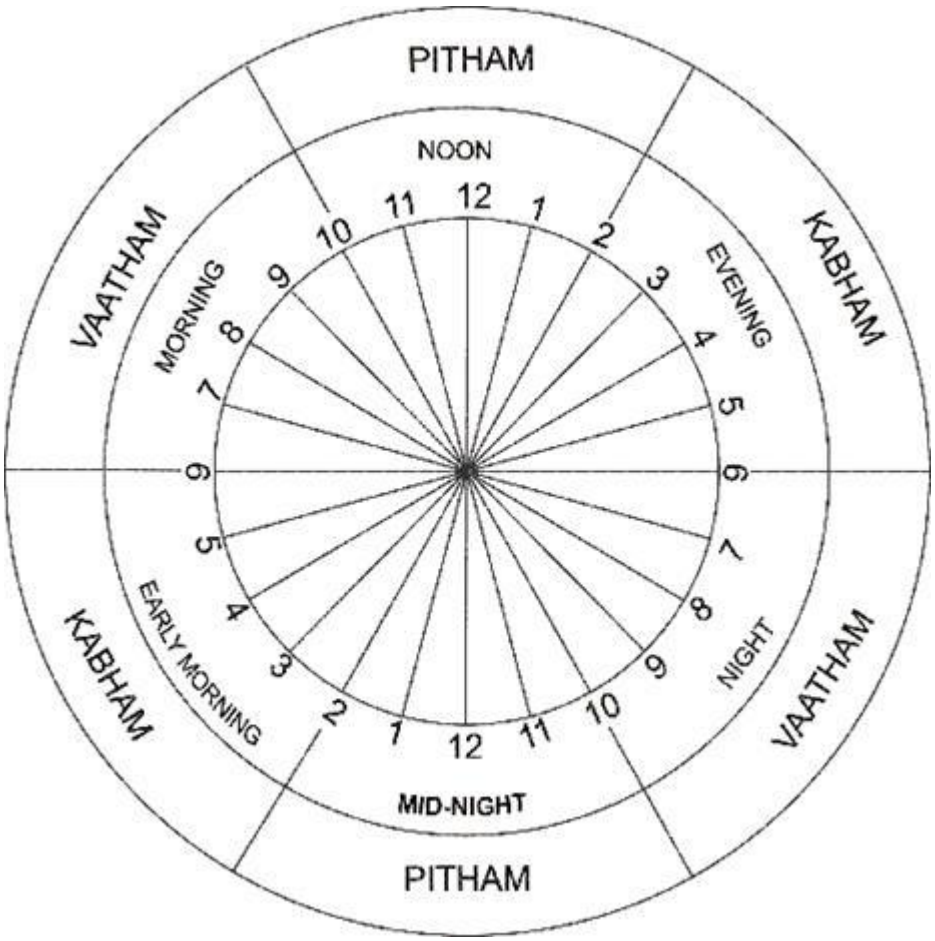
Humours (Uyir thathukkal)	Hilly tract	Sylvan tract	Cultivation area	Coastal area	Arid area
Vatham			@	#	#
Pitham		#	@		#
Kabham	#		@		#

indicates predominant and @ indicates balanced

Season *(Pozhuthu)*

Each day, is divided into six periods of four hours each, which is called siru pozhuthu. Every year, on the other hand, is divided into six seasons of two-month duration each, which is called perum pozuthu. The effect of seasons on the incidence of diseases has been defined and further, seasonal conduct has been advised to prevent these diseases. A single humour (uyir thathu) dominates over the other two in a particular season and during any specific period of a day and hence the food habits and other lifestyles must be tuned in accordingly for healthy living.

Cyclic representation of states of the three humours (uyir thathukkal) in a day



Daily regimen *(Naal Ozhukkam)*

Naal Ozhukkam mentions the systematic order of every day activities that every person needs to follow in order to avoid lifestyle disorders and related diseases. It describes the methodology to take good care of our body and mind.

i. Waking up *(Kaalai Ezhuthal)*

Our new day begins as we wake up and it is the first activity of a day. The apt time for wake-up is between 4:00 AM and 5:00 AM. As we wake-up early, we breath fresh air rich in vital respiratory gases and that also helps the three humours or Uyir thathukkal to be in the state of equilibrium. Meditation and worship performed early in the morning brings immense pleasure to one's mind.

ii. Excretion of stools and urine *(Mala salam kazhithal)*

This is the act (or) function of eliminating the waste products of digestion and other metabolic activities. Excretion of faeces and urine are activities of vaatham and hence it should be performed soon after we wake up. Urine is passed first followed by stools. It is normal to pass faeces twice a day and urine 4 times a day which when disturbed indicates abnormal bowel function. One should not suppress these two physiological reflex activities.

Certain methods have also been mentioned for cleaning after the act of defaecation in order to avoid infections.

Proper excretion indicates proper digestion and helps the three humours or *uyir thathukkal* to stay in equilibrium.

iii. Brushing of teeth *(Pal thulakkal)*

Oral cavity being the main entrance of our gastro-intestinal tract must be well maintained by taking good oral care. Plaque deposits formed as a result of mastication should be cleaned properly in order to avoid infection.

Siddhars have mentioned the use of certain herbal twigs and powders for a good dental care. The herbal twigs are considered best to be used as brush, as they are used and thrown (single use). Also, the act of chewing the herbal twig increases salivation and releases the juice of that particular twig which usually has astringent and disinfectant property. The bristles so formed help remove plaque easily away from teeth. This twig is usually selected without any nodes and from a fresh, well grown tree

In cases where people suffer from ailments like stomatitis, the use of twigs is restricted and instead the use of appropriate herbal powders is advised.

iv. Exercise

Iron rusts when not in use and, similarly, our body becomes a ground for diseases when not involved in proper physical exercise. As a part of daily regimen *(naal ozhukkam)*, Siddhars stressed on the importance of practicing yoga which includes asanas, breathing techniques, meditation techniques, etc. These practices are aimed at developing body strength as well as peace of mind resulting in health and harmony. Early morning is the best time to perform yogic exercises as it help to face the day with great energy and enthusiasm. To refresh oneself after a day's activity, physical exercises can be done in the evening. Physical exercises must be done in a well-aerated area and before meals or 2 hrs after meals

Yogic and physical exercises practiced under proper guidance along with appropriate diet habits facilitate proper functioning of internal organs, thereby leading to longevity.

v. Bath

Physical exercise is followed by a bath to clean oneself of the sweat and dirt formed as a result of one's activities. A bath before sunrise is considered good for health. Oil bath is recommended once in 4 days to bring strength to the five motor organs also known as *Panchainderiyangal*. The method prescribed is application of gingelly oil/ghee/certain medicated oil, usually followed by use of herbal bath powder *(Panchakarpam)* for washing. This practice is believed to protect the body against illness in all seasons.

Methods for an oil bath, seasonal and diet restrictions while taking an oil bath have also been clearly discussed in ancient Siddha literature

vi. Dress and Ornaments

A detailed description of dress code for men and women according to seasonal variations have been given due importance in day-to-day life. Influence of planets on humans, their relation to ornamental gems and how these can be used to treat diseases have been described in detail.

vii. Diet

Diet plays a major role in our everyday activity. Diet acts as the source of vital nutrients to gain energy and it builds our body. Improper diet habits cause disturbances in equilibrium of the three humours *(Uyir thathukkal)* and physical constituents *(Udal thathukkal)* in turn causing several diseases.

"Unavae marunthu; marunthae unavu"

This verse, meaning diet can act as medicine, explains the importance of diet.

The diet concept of Siddhars is based upon taste of foods as it indicates the natural property of the kind of food. A typical diet must therefore include a combination of 6 tastes that is best suited to the prevailing season.

Hunger (pasi - one of the 14 physiological reflexes or *Vegangal*) indicates the need for food. Diet intake nourishes the different physical constituents, viz., *Udal thathukkal* in a particular sequence and finally provides strength to our body. However, food like milk, water and meat soup provide instant strength to body.

According to Saint Thiruvalluvar, 3 main factors decide the structure of a good diet.

a) Taste

b) The constitution of person who intakes the diet

c) Time of season

a) Taste

Tastes may have a compatible counterpart or an inimical counterpart and inimical tastes should never be taken together. A particular taste of food when taken in combination with its inimical taste food might yield poisonous effects due to dietetic incompatibilities.

E.g. Milk and fish should never be taken together. Similarly, a combination of milk and green leafy vegetables is also harmful.

A diet should also include food that normalises the three humours (trithoda sama porul). The concept of inimical and compatible taste in diet is also applied for selection and preparation of Siddha medicines.

b) The constitution of person

Diet with respect to quantity and quality should be taken according to the gender, age, physical/mental activity and basic body constitution (viz., vaatham, pitham, kabham) of the person

c) Time, season, and habitat

Selection of proper diet also takes into consideration the period of day (breakfast/lunch/dinner) seasonal variations and geographic locations

viii. Sleep

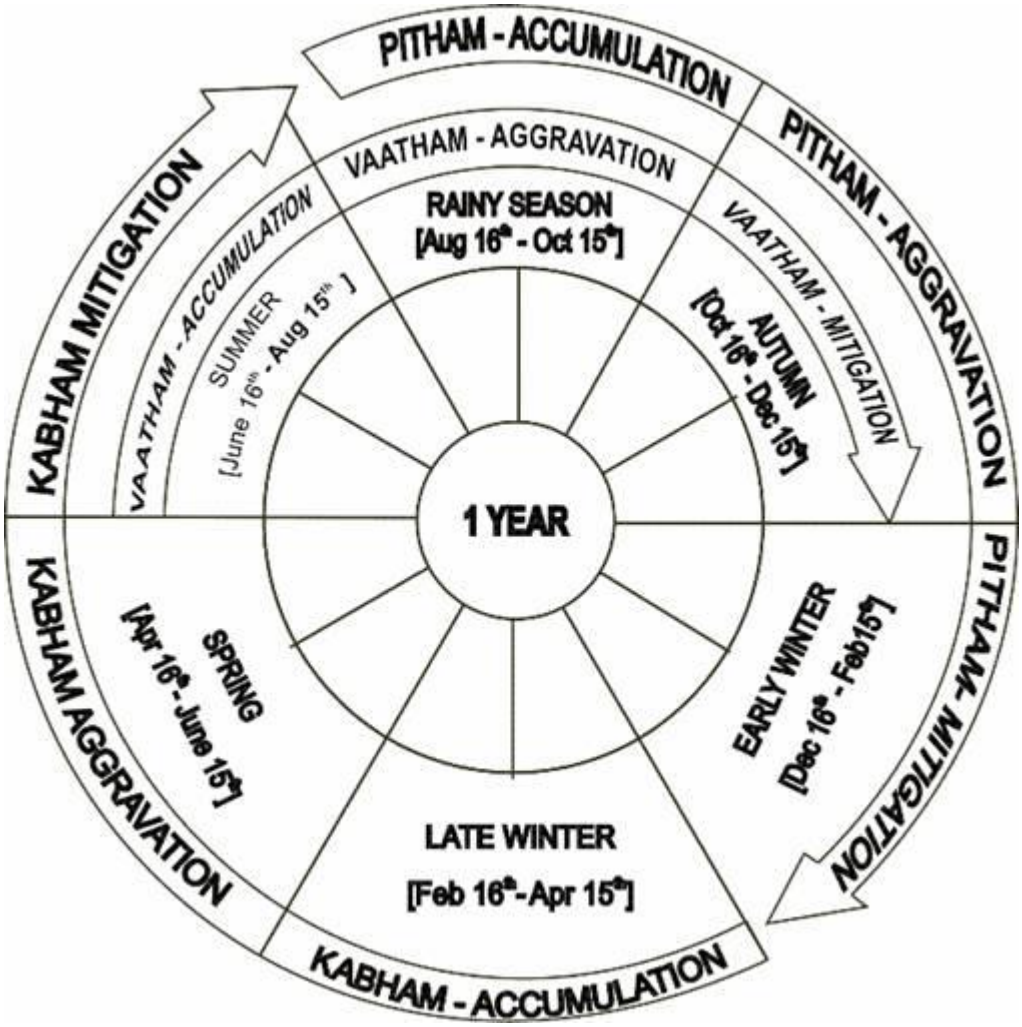
Sleep is nature's way of providing rest to our body. Proper sleep is required when our body feels tired after a day's work and it is therefore best to sleep at the end of a day. Sleep helps our body to carry out repair activities. The quantity and quality of sleep equally influences one's good health. A man deprived of sleep develops varied disorders. Siddhars have mentioned certain procedures to follow with regard to sleep.

As a part of daily regimen (Naal ozhukkam), good personality traits like silence, sincerity, charity, humanity, humility, honesty, politeness, justice, love and care for others are also encouraged since they result in purity of mind and will better chances of success in achieving eternal bliss.

Seasonal conduct *(Kaala ozhukkam)*

The seasonal conduct called Kaala ozhukkam structures out the guidelines to be followed in different seasons to prevent illnesses and help one's wellbeing. The guidelines are related to modifications in diet, lifestyle, etc. with respect to a particular season.

Cyclic representation of seasonal effects on the three humours *(Uyir Thathukkal)*:



The seasonal conduct also mentions some precautionary steps to follow during Kaalachaerkai which is a transition period of 14 days i.e., last seven days of the ongoing season and first seven days of the next season. Seasonal conduct of the ongoing season should be gradually stopped and the regimen of the next season should be gradually initiated during this period so as to help our body adapt to seasonal changes.

The table below gives brief information about the seasonal guidelines

Season	**Preferred taste**	**Preferred Diet**	**Medications**	**Preferred life style**	**State of 3 humours (*Uyir Thathukkal*), Appetite**
Rainy season from Aug 16th – Oct 15th	Sweet (Inippu), Sour (Pulippu),	Hot potency and digestible food.	Emetic, purgative drugs and appetizers	Use dry clothing. Avoid butter milk, day time	Pitham is in accumulated state,Vaatham is in aggravated

(*Kaarkaalam*)	Salty (Uvarppu)			sleep and tire some work	stateDecreased appetite
Autumn from Oct 16th – Dec 15th (Koothir kaalam)	Sweet (Inippu), Bitter (Kaippu), Astringent (Thuvarppu)	Dry and cool food, light diet	Bloodletting	Avoid curd, oil, fats, alcohol, daytime sleep sunlight, dew, heavy meals and salty diet.Use clean and dry clothes.	Pitham is in aggravated state, Vaatham is in mitigated state.
Early winter Dec 16th – Feb 15th (Muun Pani kaalam)	Sweet (*Inippu*), Sour (*Pulippu*), Salty (*Uvarppu*)	Cool	Oil (thylam) application	Use boiled water, blankets. Exposure to evening sun light and slight work is good. Always use footwear.	Pitham is in mitigated state.Increased appetite and immunity.
Late winter from Feb 16th – Apr	Sweet (*Inippu*), Sour	Avoid diet that increase	Oil (thylam) application	Use boiled	*Kabham* is in accumulated state.

15th (Pinpani Kaalam)	(*Pulippu*), Astringent (*Thuvarppu*)	s vaatham		water, blankets. Exposure to evening sun light and slight work is good. Always use footwear.	
Spring from Apr 16th – June 15th (*Ilavaenil Kaalam*)	Bitter (*Kaippu*), Pungent (*kaarppu*), Astringent (*Thuvarppu*)	Dry and hot potency food, solid, liquid and semi-solid food.	Emetic, Nasal application (*Nasiyam*)medications.	Avoid bulky diet cool diet and daytime sleep	*Kabham* is in aggravated state.
Summer June 16th – Aug 15th (*Muduvaenil Kaalam*)	Sweet (*Inippu*)	Coolant	Vatha neutralizing medications	Reside in ventilated area. Avoid food that is digested with difficulty.	*Vaatham* is in accumulated state,*Kabham* is in mitigated state.

4.Guiding Principles of Diagnosis in Siddha

To diagnose a disease, Siddhars investigate the cause of the disease, the signs and symptoms, complications if any, and pathological tissue (*udal kooru*) changes. They examine both the body and the disease together to arrive at a conclusion regarding the condition or disease. For diagnosis, two paths are followed, viz., approach to the

disease called *Noi naadal* and determination of etiology of the disease called *Noi mudal naadal*.

Essentially, the Siddha system follows a unique methodology in diagnosis of disease. It consists of eight criteria for physical examination and is called 'Envagai thervu'. These include:

i. Tongue (*Naa*)

ii. Colour (*Niram*)

iii. Speech (*Mozhi*)

iv. Eyes (*Vizhi*)

v. Stool (*Malam*)

vi. Urine (*Moothiram*)

vii. Touch (*Sparisam*)

viii. Pulse (*Naadi*)

Out of these eight entities, methods used for physical examination of urine (*Neerkuri* and *Neikkuri*) and pulse are unique to Siddha and act as confirmatory diagnostic tools.

Physical examination of urine

Neerkuri (Symptoms expressed in urine)

This is the physical examination of urine which deals with the colour, smell, quantity, frequency, specific gravity, frothiness and taste of urine.

Neikkuri

This is a method in which a drop of gingelly oil is dropped over a urine sample. The spreading pattern exhibited by the oil droplet over the surface of urine gives a confirmatory clue that helps in the diagnosis of the disease.

Pulse

Diagnosis using pulse is a very important aspect of Siddha and is the method developed by Siddhars to extend our sensual perceptions to the interior of our body to diagnose and confirm illnesses. In other words, it performs the job of present day inventions like stethoscope and sphygmomanometers. The pulse movements (pulsations) are compared to the movement of different animals according to the intensity felt for easy interpretation. It is felt mainly at 10 points, out of which the one felt over radial artery is considered the best and is felt in left hand for females and in right hand for males. It is

usually felt using 3 fingers (viz, index, middle and ring fingers) in view of assessing the states of *vaatham, pitham and kabham* simultaneously.





Siddha Drugs

Siddha pharmacology *(Gunapaadam)* deals with the detailed study of Siddha drugs. This branch of Siddha medicine describes

I. Raw drugs used in Siddha *(Moolaporutkal)*

II. Purification *(Suddhi)* of raw drugs and

III. Medicinal preparations

Siddha pharmacology is based on the concept of five primordial elements or *panchabhootham* and taste *(suvai)* of the drug. Innumerable varieties of herbs, mineral and animal products find mention in Siddha literature.

I. Raw drugs used in Siddha

On the basis of Five Element *(Panchabhootham)* theory, raw/crude drugs are divided into five major categories based on the predominant element they possess.

For example, among metals,

Metal	**Predominant element**
Gold	Earth
Lead	Water
Copper	Fire
Iron	Air
Zinc	Space

Here, the metal gold will exhibit characters and properties of the element earth as it is the predominant element in its formation and the other metals can be linked correspondingly.

Based on taste, raw drugs are divided into six categories, as follows:

Medicinal Herb	**Predominant Taste**

Sesamum indicum	Sweet
Tamarindus indicus	Sour
Cassia tora	Salty
Andrographis paniculata	Bitter
Elettaria cardamomum	Pungent
Saraca asoka	Astringent

From the above cited examples, it can be understood that *Sesamum indicum* will exhibit the properties of the sweet taste due to its dominance.

Based on their origin, raw drugs are categorized into the following classes:

i. Plant origin *(Mooligai vaguppu)*

ii. Metals and Minerals *(Dhathu vaguppu)*

iii. Animal origin *(Seevam vaguppu)*

Raw drugs based on Plant Origin

Herbal raw drugs *(Mooligai moolaporutkal)* are classified further into 11 sub-divisions based on the plant part used in preparation of a medicine.

In certain plants, the medicinal value may be attributed to a particular plant part like root, leaves, flowers etc., which is used.

E.g. *Zingiber officinale* is used for the medicinal value of its rhizhome only.

Raw drugs based on Metals and Minerals

In the Siddha system of medicine, use of metals and minerals is very much advocated. The depth of their knowledge in the field of minerals is clearly evident from the way the drug classification has been done.

Siddha literature describes 220 minerals which are of immense medicinal value. The metals and minerals are studied under the following four heads:

a. Metals *(Ulogam)*

b. Minerals *(Karasaaram)*

c. Mercury and Arsenic compound *(Pashanam)*

d. Other minerals *(Uparasam)*

Raw drugs based on Animal Origin

Raw drugs obtained from animal kingdom are also used for medicinal preparations in Siddha.

II. Purification process *(Suddhi)*

Purification of raw drugs is a process aimed at both purification as well as concentration of the raw drug. It usually involves processes like cleaning, frying, soaking and grinding with herbal juices until impurities are removed. No medicinal preparation is done without prior *Suddhi* process. This process helps raw material/crude drugs *(moolaporutkal)* to lose their undesirable or toxic effect and thereby aid better dosage efficacy.

III. Medicinal Preparations

Methods of plant containing drug preparations are based on the concept of taste, i.e., on compatible taste *(Natpu Suvai)* and inimical taste (Pagai Suvai).

The tabulation below explains this concept for each taste, which forms the basis for medicinal preparations of plant origin.

Suvai (Taste)	**Compatible taste(Natpu suvai)**	**Inimical taste *(Pagai suvai)***
Astringent *(Thuvarppu)*	Salty *(Uvarppu)*	Sour *(Pulippu)* Bitter *(Kaippu)* Pungent *(Kaarppu)*
Salty *(Uvarppu)*	Sweet *(Inippu)*	Bitter *(Kaippu)* Pungent *(Kaarppu)* Sour *(Pulippu)* Astringent *(Thuvarppu)*
Sweet *(Inippu)*	Salty *(Uvarppu)* Sour *(Pulippu)*	Bitter *(Kaippu)* Pungent *(Kaarppu)*
Bitter *(Kaippu)*	Pungent *(Kaarppu)*	Sour *(Pulippu)*

		Sweet *(Inippu)* *Salty (Uvarppu)* Astringent (Thuvarppu)
Pungent *(Kaarppu)*	-	Sweet *(Inippu)* Salty *(Uvarppu)* Astringent *(Thuvarppu)* Sour (Pulippu) Bitter (Kaippu)
Sour (pulippu)	Sweet (Inippu)	Salty (Uvarppu) Astringent (Thuvarppu) Bitter (Kaippu) Pungent (Kaarppu)

Medicinal preparations belonging to the other two classes, viz., metals & minerals and that of animal origin are based on the concept of inimical drugs *(Sathru Sarakku)* and compatible drug *(Mithuru Sarakku)*. A more detailed description of this can be found in relevant Siddha literature.

Siddha system classifies all medicinal preparations into 64 categories, of which 32 are internal medications and 32 are external medications and methods.

Speciality of Siddha Pharmaceuticals

Siddhars successfully used their extensive knowledge of iatrochemistry, minerals, metals and plants from time immemorial. Processes like calcination of mercury, minerals, metals and the preparation of a super salt- 'Muppu', animated mercury pills with high potency possessing marvelous properties of transmuting metals and capable of rejuvenating the entire human system bear ample testimony to the fact that even in ancient times, when knowledge in chemical technology was not advanced or developed, Siddhars had an unparalleled knowledge of medicine preparation. The above processes are unique to Siddha system of medicine and are not known to other medical systems in India or other countries.

The preparations in which Siddhars specialized are metallic preparations *(chunnam)* which are alkaline; waxy preparations *(mezhugu)*; and preparations which are impervious to the water and flame *(kattu)*. These preparations have a longer shelf life and their potency and efficacy improve with time. They do wonders in very little dosage.

Siddhars also developed the knowledge of bringing inorganic substances into atomic and ionic form which can be easily absorbed in the human system when ground with herbal juices and put in the fire with a calculated number of cow dung cakes. Lakhs of such medicinal formulations are available in Siddha literature, a few printed and several others still in manuscripts and palm leaves.





Pharmacotherapy

Introduction:

Siddha (chemico-philosphical system) is one of the ancient system of medicine. According to Siddha, there are 4448 types of diseases and 64 types of medicines (32 types of internal medicines and 32 types of external medicines). Siddha system is having potentiality in curing diseases.

Details about pharmacotherapy are as follows:

- Raw drugs in Siddha
- Suddhi of raw drugs
- Siddha pharmacology
- Diagnostic method in Siddha
- Treatment

Gunapaadam (Siddha Pharmacology):

Gunam means properties of drugs, paadam means detail study. Gunapaadam means detailed study of drugs. Siddha medicine was discovered by Siddhars who were the greatest scientist both in material and spiritual aspects of ancient days. Gunapaadam(Siddha pharmacology) is dealing with this comprehensive subject of the ancient chemico-philosphical system.

The universe and human bodies are composed of primordial elements of panchabhudham which

are *Nilam* (earth), *Neer* (water), *Thee* (fire), *Vali* (air), *Visumbu* (space). So Gunapaadam (Siddha pharmacology) is mainly based on the *Panchabhudham* and *Suvai* (taste).

According to panchabhudham concept, moolapporutkkal (crude drugs) are divided into 5 classifications which are as follows:

- Nila (earth) kooru moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- Neer (water) kooru moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- Thee (fire) kooru moolapporutkkal (raw drugs
- Vali (air) kooru moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- Agaayam (space) kooru moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)

Suvai (Taste) has got significant place in Siddha. Our tongue experiences these tastes when drug is administered orally. The taste parameter reveals dynamic of Siddha preparations. Six tastes are known as sweet, sour, salt, pungent, bitter and astringent.

These are:

Suvai (Taste)	**Bhudhaamsam (Elements)**
Inippu (Sweet)	Man (earth) + Neer (water)
Pullippu (Sour)	Man (earth) + Thee(fire)
Uppu (Salt)	Neer (water) + Thee(fire)
Kaippu (Bitter)	Vali (air) + Vin(wind)
Kaarppu (Pungent)	Vali (air) + Thee (fire)
Thuvarppu (Astringent)	Man (earth) + Vali (air)

According to suvai(taste) concept, moolapporutkkal (raw drugs) are divided into 6 classifications which are as follows:

- inippu(sweet) suvai(taste) moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- pulippu(sour) suvai(taste) moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- uppu(salt) suvai(taste) moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- kaippu(bitter) suvai(taste) moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- kaarppu(pungent) suvai(taste) moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)
- thuvarppu(astringent) suvai(taste) moolapporutkkal (raw drugs)

Gunam (Property) Siddha has described twenty one properties, which are comparable to physical and pharmacological activity of the drugs. Each property described has specific role to play in Siddha drug formulation.

Veeriyam (potency) is described as active constituent of the drug. This constituent is responsible for pharmacological activity of the medicinal herb and other drugs. The drugs have cold and hot potency.

Vemmai (hot) potency is neutralize the Vaathamkkuttram and kabhakkuttram.

Thanmai (cold) potency is neutralize the Pithamkkuttram.

Vipaham and **prabhavam** parameters are comparable with drug mechanism and therapeutic activity of the drug.

Moolapporutkkal (Raw drugs in Siddha):

In Siddha, there exist three types of moolapporutkkal (raw drugs) for the preparation of the drugs.

The classification of the moolapporutkkal is as follows:

- Mooligai(Plant kingdom)
- Dhatu(Metals & other Mineral kingdom)
- Jeevam(Animal kingdom)

Mooligai (Plant kingdom)

In Siddha, more than 1500 plants are in use. According to Siddha, mooligai is divided into 11 subdivisions as per the part used.

The subdivision of mooligai is as follows:

- Vergal (Roots) used medicinal plants
- Tharaikeezh thandugal (Rhizome, Bulb, Tuber, Corn) used medicinal plants
- Thandugal & Kattaigal (Stems & Woods) used medicinal plants
- Pattaigal(Barks) used medicinal plants
- Ilaigal(Leaves) used medicinal plants
- Puttrugal(Galls) used medicinal plants
- Malargal(Flowers) used medicinal plants
- Kanigal(Fruits) used medicinal plants
- Vidhaigal(Seeds) used medicinal plants

- Samoolangal(Whole plants) used medicinal plants
- Konthu & Pisin (Resin & Pisin) used medicinal plants

Dhatu (Metals & other Mineral kingdom)

In Siddha, 220 minerals are used. According to Siddha, dhatu is divided into 4 subdivisions as per the component.

The subdivision of dhatu is as follows:

- Ulogam (Metals)-11
- Karasaaram (Minerals)-25
- Pashanams (Mercury & Arsenic compound)-64
- Uparasams (Other minerals)-120

Jeevam (Animal kingdom)

In Siddha, Jeeva porutkkal from ant to elephant are used.

Collection of the medicinal plants:

All Siddhars observe certain taboos while collecting the medicinal plants. They see to it that their shadow does not fall on the plant and face east while collecting it. They believe that the shadow blocks the life giving rays or healing power of the sun that is continuously transmitted to the medicinal plants through the light. Before collecting the plant Siddhars utters a prayer to the sun and also to the plant requesting for its efficacy and quick relief to their patients.

Plants are growing in so many regions like hills, forest etc. In hill station plants are having immense medicinal efficacy as compared to other station.

Suddhi(Purification & Concentration):

First step of the preparation of the drugs is suddhi. During suddhi, the moolaporutkkal (raw drugs) are purified, processed and concentrated well.

For eg: iron is processed with naval (Syzygium cumini) fruits juice, the impurities are removed and thereafter purified and concentrated.





Special Therapies in Siddha

Besides pharmacotherapy, there are several special therapies unique to Siddha. Some of them are listed below:

I Varmam

'Varmam' is a branch of Siddha system of medicine, which initially evolved as an ancient Dravidian martial art. Later, *Varmam* practice had an interesting transformation to a healing science. Even though it stands as a branch of Siddha system of medicine, it holds a potential to establish itself as a specialty healing therapy.

According to theory, there are *Varmam* points in the body which are vital energy storing points through which vital energy is transmitted to the various parts of the body and all the functions of the body are mediated. 108 *Varmam* points are defined and these are used to stimulate energy, heal disease or stimulate the immune mechanism. However, the same points if wrongly activated may cause pathological changes or diseases and may even result in death. The practice and method of pressing the *varmam* points need a great expertise and even a slight deviation may cause adverse results or danger. Among the 108, 12 are major or vital points which control the function of the vital organs of the body.

It is understood that depletion or stagnation of the flow of *'pranan'* or vital energy at the *varmam* points causes disease.

II. Thokkanam

The term *Thokkanam* is a combination of two words *'Thokku'*, meaning skin and *'anam'* meaning support or tone or heat. *Thokkanam* also called *Marthanam*, is a structured massage technique which is mainly used in treatment of chronic *vaatham* ailments. It can however, also be used in *pitham* and *kabham* ailments. This therapy practised in nine methods gives excellent results even without any internal drug administration. *'Theran Tharu'* describes this technique in detail.

Benefits of *thokkanam*

1. Tones skin, muscles and nerves

2. Disseminates vaayu and eliminates it if it is in excess

3. Improves nutrition of muscles

4. Relaxes and increases sleep

5. Rejuvenates and increases sexual power

6. Removes body pain

III. Vaasi (Pranayamam)

Vaasi yogam is a branch of science dealing with the practice of correct breathing. There are different phases in science of breathing- physical, mental and spiritual. Controlled breathing is the scientific method of charging oneself with vitality and personal magnetism and was known to the ancients. Inspiration (*Poorakam*), suppression (*Kumbagam*) and expiration (*Rechagam*) are three vital steps in the practice of vaasi, which should be in a ratio of 1:4:2.

Siddha science believes that if a man breathes at the rate of 15/minute he takes 21,600 breaths/day and at this rate he can live for a period of at least 120 years. This therapy is mainly employed for present day lifestyle diseases arising due to improper breathing habits and several other stress-related diseases.

Other offshoots of the Siddha system

Vaastu sastiram

This is the branch of Siddha science dealing with planning and designing of a house or any living environment based on the positions of *'Vaastu Purushan'* –the deity believed to be residing in any site and the theory of *'Panchabhootam'*. This science was developed with a purpose to provide a house that ensures health, happiness and peace of mind. Accordingly, it details out certain guidelines to be followed right from selection of site to final construction of house involving several calculations which result in perfect hygienic living condition.

Astrology and Siddha

Astrology has a significant place in Siddha science as it deals with the relationship between the planets and human beings. There is considerable Siddha literature explaining the effect of planetary forces on every human, from the time of his/her birth to death. There are also references indicating that certain organs and their functions are controlled by the influence of the planets. The Siddha texts provide instances dealing with the influence of planets on the health and illness of individuals living on earth. Siddha science also deals with the positive use of planetary influences for treating certain diseases.

Siddha and Veterinary Science

Siddha medicine also deals with veterinary science. There are several references in Siddha literature describing wide range of veterinary disease and their corresponding medications.

Research

Siddha system of medicine has a potential for evolving drugs particularly with respect to herbal antibiotics, herbal anaesthetics, herbal drugs for metabolic disorders etc. and hence have been looked as a base information for carrying out intensive inter-

disciplinary research by biochemists, microbiologists, pharmacologists, endocrinologists etc.





Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is Siddha?
2. What are the basic principles of Siddha?
3. What are the branches in Siddha?
4. What is the prime objective of Siddha?
5. What is the definition of health in Siddha?
6. How Siddha approach and diagnose the diseases?
7. What is Mukkutram?
8. How Mukkutram functions in body?
9. What is the role of Vaatha Kutram in body?
10. What is the role of Pitha Kutram in body?
11. What is the role of Kaba Kutram in body?
12. What are the factors affecting the health in Siddha?
13. What are the specializations in Siddha treatment?
14. How to normalize the Mukkutram?
15. What are the five important forms of Vaatham among ten?
16. What are the five forms of Pitham?
17. What are the five types of Kabam?
18. What are the classifications of medicine?

1. What is Siddha?

According to Tamil literature, Siddham means mind. Siddha means achievements with perfection. Those who attained an intellectual level of perfection were called as *Siddhars* . Most of the diseases are related to mind. The primitive cause of the disease is the variation and disturbance in mind. Thus, we have to treat the mind to cure

the physical problem. So Siddhars stressed the value of leading calm, peaceful life with the help of yoga, pranayama etc. By this fact, one can understand that Siddha not only deals with the physical illness, but also with the mental illness.

2. What is the basic principle of Siddha?

Universe is the macrocosam and the human being is the microcosm. What are all present in the macrocosm present in the human body (microcosm) also. The primordial five elements of panchabootham are the compounds of anything found in nature. Man is constant interacting with coamos. When these are disturbance to this rhythum it manifests into disease.

Body is composed of five elements, the substance and function is maintained by food which also contain the panchabhudas as their compounds of the basic principle of Siddha is *"Unave marunthu, Maruthae unavu"* . That is food is medicine, medicine is food, which means by taking the proper diet one can protect once body from all ailment, and also at the time of any diseases by regulating the dietary habits one can get rid of the diseases.

3. What are the branches of Siddha?

The branches of Siddha are:

1] Vadham

2] Vaidhyam

3] Yogam

4] Gnanam

4. What is the primitive objective of Siddha?

Siddhars primitive aim is to attain the eternity. To attain this, living a healthy life is very important. Thus the aim is to lead a life without any disease and to promote the health.

5. What is the definition of health in Siddha?

Healthy body with a healthy mind is the definition of health in Siddha.

6. How Siddha approaches to diagnose the disease?

In Siddha diagnosis is based on reading of pulse. One can understand this by *Noi naadi noi mudhal naadi athu thanikkum Vaai naadai vaaiyppa cheyal* ....By assessing the pulse one can easily diagnose the nature of disease, even if the patient is in the sate of unconscious. In the pulse the three important classifications are there i.e. *Vali (Vaatham), Azhal (Pitham), Iyam (Kabam) – (Mikinum kuraiyinum noiseyyum noolor Vali muthaai enniya moontru* – Thirukkural) with specific measurements. By the variation of the pulse, one can differentiate the diseases. And here *Envaigaithervu* is also essential. By the eight diagnosing methods one can easily arrive of the diagnosis of the disease.

7. What is Mukkutram?

The *Mukkutram* are Vali (Vaatham), Azhal (Pitham), Iyyam (Kabam). These are the composition of the any two *Panchabootham* **.** In a normal person the Mukkutram must be in perfect balance. Each *Kutram* possess its original character. These three *Kutram* s are also influenced by the nature of food, nature of place where the persons live, season, climate, mental health.. etc. Persons may be single *Kutram* or combination of two *Kutram* depending upon this one can assess the constitution of the individual .

8. How Mukkutram functions in the body?

One can easily understand that the *Mukkutram* function by the following stanza

“Vaathamai padaithu,

Pithamvanniyaai kaathu,

Silethuma seethamaai thudaithu” (Theran)

By this one can understand *vaatham* helps in Inception, *Pitham* helps in preservation and *Kabam* helps in demolition.

9. What is the role of *Vaatha Kutram* in the body?

Vaatham is production. It is responsible for the production / implementation of thoughts to action. Generally, its function is more related to cerebral activities like, thinking and action. There are 10 classification in *vaatham*.

10. What is the role of *Pitha kutram* in the body?

Pitham is for preserving the body. It is responsible for the normal metabolism. It controls the digestion, the level of haemoglobin [ayachenthavalam], the movement of limbs, the function of eyes to enhance vision, the complexion of skin and the sharpness of the mind etc.

11. What is the role of *Kabam* in the body?

Kabam's function is destructive in nature. It can be understand by the term *"Silethuma seethumai thudaitthu"* According to Siddha principle in old age the cause of death is by *Kabam* . There are 5 classifications in *Kabam*

12. What are all the factors mainly affecting the health in Siddha?

Diet [Unavu murai] and mind are mainly affecting the health. According to great Siddhar Thiruvalluvar *"M arunthena vendaavaam yaakkaikku arunthiyadhu atrathu potri unnin"*

13. What is the specialization in Siddha treatment?

Siddha treatment is basically not only curing the diseases but also prevention. According to Siddha concept *"Varumun kaappom",* that is prevention is better than cure. Since the principle aim is to achieve the eternity. It also helps in longevity through *Kaayakalpam,* that is rejuvenator

14. How to normalize the Mukkutram?

If the *Mukkutram* are not in normal range, that is the sign of the disease. To keep the *Mukkutram* to normal, we can follow the following principles.

"Viresanathaal vaathan thaalum,

Vamanathaal Pithamn thaalum,

Nasiya anjanathaal Kabam thaalum thaane"

It means Vaatham is balanced by purgation, Pitham is balanced by emesis and Kabam is balanced by Nasal Insufflations with liquids and by applying medicine in the eye.

15. What are the five important forms of Vaatham among ten?

These are corresponding to the nerve plexuses of the body. They are

ABANAN: This corresponds to the pelvic plexus.

Function **:** It's main function is to control the excretory function.

SAMANAN: This corresponds to solar plexus in the navel region.

Function: It's main function is to control the digestive system.

PRANAN: This corresponds to cardiac plexus in the heart region.

Function **:** This is responsible for the circulation, breathing and biocombustion of nutrients

UDHANAN: This corresponds to the plexus in the throat region, that is pharyngeal plexus.

Function **:** It is responsible for the speech, swallowing, breathing, conduction of food, etc

VIYANAN: This corresponds to the naso ciliary plexus at the root of the nose and the base of skull which spreads allover to the body.

Function: It is responsible for the movement of the body and the nutrition of the thathus

What are the five forms of Pitham?

They are

ANALA PITHAM: It denotes inherent heat in the stomach

FUNCTION: This gives appetite and it is responsible for digestion

PRASAGA PITHAM: It denotes the colour pigments of the skin

FUNCTION: This is responsible for the complexion of the skin.

RANJAHA PITHAM: It denotes the haemoglobin

FUNCTION: This is responsible for the colour of blood.

AALOSAHA PITHAM: It denotes the aqueous humour

FUNCTION: This is responsible for the maintenance of vision.

SAATHAAGA PITHAM: It denotes the life energy.

FUNCTION **:** This activates the whole body.

17. What are the five types of Kabam?

The five types of Kabam are as follows

KILATHAGAM: It denotes the saliva

FUNCTION: It is secreted by the three pairs of salivary glands, which is useful in mastication.

THARPAGAM: This is cerebrospinal fluid.

FUNCTION: This is responsible for the protection of cerebrum.

POTHAGAM: It denotes the lymph

FUNCTION: This is responsible for the immunity, absorption of excess fluid and return to the blood stream.

SANTHIGAM: It denotes the synovial fliud.

FUNCTION: This is responsible for the lubrication and free movement of joints.

18. What are the classifications of medicine?

The classification of medicine in Siddha medicine is divided into 64 types. It is further classified into two types, that is **32 types of internal medicine and 32 types of external medicine** based on the administration of medicine.

32 types of Internal Medicine in Siddha.

- Surasa,
- Saaru
- Kudineer
- Karkam
- Utkazhi
- Adai
- Chooranam
- Pittu
- Vadagam
- Vennei
- Manappaagu
- Nei

- Rasaayanam
- Ilagam / Legiyam
- Ennai
- Mathirai
- Kadugu
- Pakkuvam
- Thenooral
- Theeneer
- Mezhugu
- Kuzhambu
- Padhangam
- Chendhooram
- Parpam
- Kattu
- Urukku
- Kalangu
- Chunnam
- Karpam
- Sathu
- Gurukuligai.